

69% OF RESPONDENTS CLAIM THEY DID NOT HAVE SEX BEFORE MARRIAGE

then no more than the family's designated agent to neutralise the threat posed by the young daughter-in-law. Such overt struggles may be going underground in Westernised families which feel compelled to pay lip service to the modern ideal of the couple as the primary constituent of the family. Their underlying rationale, however, has left deep markings on the Indian psyche in its preference for arranged marriages.

Perhaps the greatest attraction of an arranged marriage is that it takes away the young person's anxiety around finding a mate. Whether you are plain or good-looking, fat or thin, you can be reasonably sure that a suitable mate will be found for you. Although physical beauty is important for the

Indian girl, it does not command the same premium in the selection of a partner as it does in Western societies.

What, then, of the universal dream of love that constitutes and seeks to find its culmination in the couple? The imperiousness of erotic passion, a love that demands (in Tolstoy's words) "madder music, stronger wine", which is seen by many young Western men and women as their birthright, a promise that the life must redeem, is recognised as a fantasy by most Indians. It is a fantasy, however, that does not lose its magnetic power by being acknowledged as such. The fantasy finds a home, for instance, in Indian movies where love marriage reigns and is depicted as the royal road to conjugal happiness. In a culture that is deeply hierarchical, with

caste and class barriers which are not easy to cross even by the god Kama, the dream is of love unimpeded by the shackles of family obligations and duties toward the old and all the other keepers of society's traditions. The pleasure we take in this subversion is one of the many enduring fascinations of the Bollywood love story, a vehicle for the vicarious satisfaction of our hidden desires and obscure longings. Indian movies are thus not a guide to Indian marriages but a doorway into the universal dream of love; what they offer are not role models for the young but romantic nostalgia for the freshness of love's vision to men and women of all ages. In other words, Indian movies of impossible loves have been delegated the unenviable task of making us forget the reality of arranged marriage lurking beyond the dark foyers of the cinema hall.

The dream of finding love does not disappear in an arranged marriage. This love, though, is a quieter affair, without the delicious delirium that can mark the periods of courtship and the beginning of a marriage in the West. Its feeling-tone is of contented togetherness rather than ecstasy. In other words, the dream of love remains necessary to a marriage. The difference is that in arranged marriages, it is expected that love will be less

Between an arranged and love marriage, which do you think is better?

		MALE	FEMALE
Arranged marriage	77	76	78
Love marriage	20	22	19

All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Won't say.

MERGER AND UNION

Seventy six per cent of Indian men still prefer a marriage arranged by their parents as do 78 per cent of women. Where 72 per cent of the youth between the ages of 21 and 30 believe in arranged marriages, the figure climbs to 81 per cent as expected in couples between the ages of 41 and 50. Even the Indian working woman seems to prefer seeking her parent's permission, with 74 per cent saying arranged marriage is better. It seems Indian men and women are still content being tied to the umbilical cord.

THE GEOGRAPHY PROFESSOR GAVE
PRIVATE TUITION ON DIFFERENT CONTOURS.
THE BIOLOGY TEACHER COULDN'T STOP THANKING HIM.

SAVASUTRA CONTOURED CONDOMS. WHO DO YOU WANT TO BE TONIGHT?

